

Hilton receives Trump’s nod for governor

If the endorsement consolidates GOP voters, it could help a Democrat win the job.

By Seema Mehta

President Trump endorsed conservative commentator Steve Hilton for California governor late Sunday night.

The endorsement could have a major impact on a race that remains up for grabs, with recent opinion polls showing Hilton and his top Republican rival, Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco, as top contenders.

Hilton “is a truly fine man, one who has watched as this once great State has gone to Hell,” Trump posted on Truth Social at 10:21 p.m. Pacific time, adding that he has known the candidate for many years.

Trump praised Hilton while attacking the record of Gov. Gavin Newsom, using a derogatory name for the governor. Newsom is serving the last year of his final term as governor as he weighs running for president in 2028.

“Gavin Newscum and the Democrats have done an absolutely horrendous job. People are fleeing, crime is increasing, and Taxes are the highest of any State in the Country, maybe the World. Steve can turn it around, before it is too late, and, as President, I will help him to do so! With Federal help,” Trump said.

Hilton’s campaign called the president’s endorsement “powerful.”

“Thank you, Mr. President!” his campaign posted on X. “This is the moment California has been waiting for!”

On Monday, Bianco said Hilton, a former Fox News commentator, has no chance of becoming California’s next governor.

“For me, this has never [See Governor, A7]

Steyer criticized for past dealings

Rivals for governor target investment choices of the billionaire’s former firm. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



MAJID SAEEDI Getty Images



JULIA DEMAREE NIKHINSON Associated Press

IN TEHRAN, top, a man walks in a building destroyed by an Israeli-U.S. attack. “The entire country can be taken out in one night,” President Trump said.

Crew travels farther than any humans in history

NASA’s Artemis II mission completes its lunar flyby

By Noah Haggerty

NASA’s Artemis II crew flew past the moon Monday, traveling farther from Earth than any humans in history and becoming the first to see some sections of the moon’s far side in the sunlight with the naked eye.

The four astronauts, sitting in the dark of their capsule, described the far side in eloquent detail: Geometric patterns of browns, blues and greens amid the moon’s typical shades of gray. Scratches and steep canyon walls dotting the lunar landscape. Some areas looking as if ponds of choppy water, invigorated by winds, had suddenly frozen. Others, as if they had been [See Artemis, A6]



NASA

CREW members became the first to see some sections of the far side of the moon with the naked eye.

SoCal talent draws new aerospace firm

By Laurence Darmiento

Aerospace startup Hermeus is moving its headquarters to El Segundo from Atlanta as it aims to build autonomous hypersonic aircraft for the military, the latest sign of revival in the region’s aerospace and defense sectors.

The company, valued at \$1 billion, is opening execu-

tive offices and a facility where it will design and build its next prototype, a supersonic plane intended to hit Mach 3 — faster than any modern warplane.

The company’s goal is to eventually develop a hypersonic plane reaching Mach 5, or five times the speed of sound, and Southern California has the engineering talent base to help achieve that, executives said.

“Building a lot of aircraft

developmentally very quickly, doing iterative developments, it really doesn’t exist anywhere out in the world other than SpaceX — and we’ve recruited a lot of talent from there over the years,” said co-founder and Chief Executive AJ Piplica, a Georgia Tech alumnus.

“We’re now at a point in the company’s trajectory where we are scaling what the team can do,” he added.

Elon Musk founded

SpaceX in El Segundo 24 years ago and later moved its operations to Hawthorne, where the company still maintains a large campus despite moving its headquarters to Texas in 2024.

El Segundo and other South Bay cities have witnessed explosive growth in recent years, with scores of startups in aerospace and defense tech — many founded by former SpaceX [See Hypersonic, A11]

Trump holds fast to Iran deadline, intensifies threat

The president claims talks are underway. Critics say bombing plans are illegal.

By Ana Ceballos, Gavin J. Quinton, Nabih Bulos and Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Monday that the United States and Iran are at a “critical point” in negotiating a potential ceasefire agreement, even as he continued to threaten military strikes against Tehran ahead of a Tuesday night deadline to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

In a lengthy news briefing at the White House, the president renewed warnings he first issued in an expletive-laden Easter Sunday message, threatening to strike Iran’s vital infrastructure if Tehran does not agree to open the Strait of Hormuz by 5 p.m. PDT on Tuesday.

“The entire country can be taken out in one night and that night might be tomorrow night,” Trump told reporters.

If the attacks happen, he said, Iran’s bridges would be “decimated” and “every power plant in Iran will be out of business, burning, exploding and never to be used again” within a four-hour period.

Despite the threats, Trump said that he believed Iranian leaders were negotiating in “good faith” and that the war could end “very quickly” if they agreed with certain terms.

“The people that we are

negotiating with now on behalf of Iran are much more reasonable,” he said.

Trump declined to identify whom the United States is negotiating with but said the biggest challenge has been establishing reliable communication channels with Iranian leaders. He also declined to say whether he was prepared to offer Iran assurances that he would be willing to wind down the conflict.

“I can’t tell you — it depends on what they do,” he said. “This is a critical period.”

Mediators from Egypt, Pakistan and Turkey sent the United States and Iran a draft proposal of the 45-day ceasefire on Friday, the Associated Press reported.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei rejected the latest ceasefire proposal, saying Monday that the American demands were “both highly excessive and unusual, as well as illogical.” Iranian leaders have also dismissed Trump’s diplomatic overtures as “unrealistic” and have denied direct talks with the United States.

With the deadline hours away and Tehran publicly rejecting the terms on the table, the prospects of a ceasefire deal by Tuesday remained uncertain.

The European Union, meanwhile, urged both sides toward a diplomatic resolution, and urged against targeting infrastructure that could impact civilians.

“Any targeting of civilian infrastructure, namely energy facilities, is illegal and unacceptable,” EU Chief Antont [See Iran, A5]

Lebanese fearful as Israel pushes to create buffer zone

Southern villages are emptying as hunt for Hezbollah escalates amid the Iran war.

By Nabih Bulos

KFAR CHOUBA, Lebanon — The fear is always there, but it’s worst at night.

That’s when the Israeli troops stationed a few hundred yards down the road come into this mountain village less than a mile from Lebanon’s border with Israel, searching houses and detaining residents at will.

“When it gets dark, the horror starts,” said Walid Nasser, a retired police officer and a municipal board member.

He got up and pointed out the window to somewhere hidden in the gray clouds wreathing the mountains overlooking Kfar Chouba.

“If there wasn’t fog, you’d see the Israelis up there,” he said. “They’re watching us all the time. ... You keep

thinking, ‘Now they’ll knock on the door, now they’ll barge into the house.’”

Hussein Abdul-Aal has similar fears. His house on Kfar Chouba’s eastern edge was one of the closest to the Israelis’ position. In recent days, Abdul-Aal said, they searched the three houses near him, prompting their owners to leave. The last residents still in the neighborhood are Abdul-Aal, his wife, their two cats and the abandoned dogs they feed.

“It’s my dream now to surrender fully to sleep, to be relaxed and sleep calmly at night,” Abdul-Aal said.

This is life now in Kfar Chouba since fighting between the Lebanese Shiite militant group Hezbollah and Israel escalated last month, triggered by the U.S. and Israeli war on Iran.

Abdul-Aal, a 72-year-old retired high school sociology teacher with an avuncular smile, likened residents’ behavior around Israeli troops to a lazy student hoping they’re not called on in class.

“You try to make yourself [See Lebanon, A3]

His challenge: Riding mass transit to LAX

By Andrew J. Campa

Getting to Los Angeles International Airport is a challenge, even if you are being chauffeured in a limousine.

But with traffic worsening and the Olympics coming in 2028, there is a growing push from public transit agencies and airport authorities for more people to use mass transit to get to their flight.

LAX’s long-delayed Skylink people mover system is scheduled to finally open this year, and officials

estimate it will transport 85 million passengers a year. The opening of Skylink will bring new fees for ride-hailing in and out of LAX, part of a congestion pricing plan aimed at easing car traffic at the airport.

So how difficult and realistic is it to use mass transit to the airport? How much money and brain cells do you save? How much time do you waste and how practical is usage, particularly if you’re coming from an area far from LAX?

At the urging of Times readers, I decided to find [See Transit, A6]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

PASSENGERS wait to board a Metrolink train at L.A.’s Union Station, one of the region’s transit hubs.

Doubts about Pratt’s address

L.A. mayoral candidate Spencer Pratt moved after Palisades fire, raising eligibility questions. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Hot at the plate out of the gate

Dodgers’ Andy Pages is off to a sizzling start, tied for the most hits in the majors through nine games. **SPORTS, B10**

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Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Guthrie returns to ‘Today’ show

It’s the anchor’s first time back at work since the disappearance of her mother. **BUSINESS, A9**

Replacement for Colbert named

CBS will put cost-saving “Comics Unleashed” in the “Late Show” time slot. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 76/57. **B6**



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